

Access to Work

A funding guide for assistive writing software

Access to Work is a UK government scheme that pays for assistive technology — including software like Dyslexia Write — for employed and self-employed people whose disability or health condition affects their work. This guide walks through the application, the wording that helps your case, a funding request template, and what to expect while you wait.

1. The honest timeline

Access to Work's own target is to decide within 25 working days of a complete application. In practice, current DWP-reported figures show average decision times running well beyond that target, and applicants have reported waits of several months during periods of high demand — the scheme has publicly acknowledged a case backlog it is working through.

This isn't a reflection of your application — it's the scheme's processing capacity. The practical takeaway: apply as early as possible, keep a record of your reference number and submission date, and don't assume something's wrong if you haven't heard back within a few weeks.

2. The application, step by step

Step 1 — Apply to Access to Work

Apply online at GOV.UK or call the Access to Work helpline on 0800 121 7479. You'll need your National Insurance number and a short description of how dyslexia (or another condition) affects your work. If you're employed, you'll also need a workplace contact who can confirm you work there.

- When asked what support you need, be specific: "assistive technology software for dyslexia, specifically Dyslexia Write" — a named product is faster to process than a general request.

Step 2 — Workplace needs assessment

If your case is approved for assessment, the DWP arranges a workplace needs assessment — usually a phone or video call, typically 30–60 minutes, with an independent assessor. They'll ask about your role, the tasks you find difficult, and what's already helped.

- If you have already tried Dyslexia Write (the free tier works for this), say so — assessors are more likely to recommend a tool you have hands-on experience with, rather than guess at what might help.

Step 3 — Recommendation and approval

The assessor writes a report recommending specific tools. If assistive software is recommended, the DWP approves a grant covering the cost. For software like Dyslexia Write, Access to Work typically covers the full cost.

- The recommendation is guidance, not a binding requirement. If the assessor suggests a different product but you prefer Dyslexia Write, you can request it instead — you have the right to choose the tool that works best for you.

Step 4 — Claim your licence

Once your grant is approved, contact us with your Access to Work reference number. We set up your account the same day and invoice the DWP directly — you don't handle payment or paperwork.

3. Funding request template

Use this if you need to put your request in writing — to an employer, a SENCO, or as supporting notes for your Access to Work assessor. Adjust the bracketed sections for your situation.

For an employer or Access to Work assessor:

"I have dyslexia, which affects [specific tasks — e.g. writing emails and reports, reading long documents]. I'd like to request funding for Dyslexia Write, an assistive writing and reading tool, through [Access to Work / our workplace adjustments budget]. I have already tried it and found it helped with [specific benefit]. Could we look at getting this funded?"

For a SENCO or school/university disability service:

"I have dyslexia and I'm finding [specific challenge — e.g. keeping up with reading load, structuring written coursework] difficult. Could we look at an access arrangements assessment, and whether assistive software like Dyslexia Write could be funded through the school/college SEN budget or Disabled Students' Allowance?"

4. While you wait

You don't need to wait for approval to start building the habit. Dyslexia Write's free tier gives you real, unlimited use of the core writing support — so you can genuinely say "I've already tried it and it helps" when the assessment call happens, which is exactly the kind of concrete evidence assessors respond well to.

- Keep a note of your application date and reference number somewhere you won't lose it.
- If you haven't heard anything after a few weeks, it's reasonable to call the Access to Work helpline and ask for a status update quoting your reference number.
- If your circumstances change (new job, role change, condition worsening), you can update the DWP directly — it won't restart your case from scratch in most circumstances.

DyslexiaWrite — AI-powered writing and reading support, built for how dyslexic people think.

Start free at dyslexiawrite.com · Full walkthrough at dyslexiawrite.com/access-to-work

This guide is general information, not official DWP guidance — always confirm current process details at gov.uk/access-to-work.